

THE NEW TERROR

The Malegaon blast probe exposes the hidden face of Hindu militancy and what is termed 'reverse terrorism'. With crucial elections nearing, the new threat has serious implications for the political leadership as well as security agencies entrusted with countering terrorism.



ACCUSED: Kulkarni (right) with former Bajrang Dal president Jaibhan Singh Pavaitya; Thakur at the time of her arrest



EMBARRASSMENT: Rajnath (right), Chauhan (left) with Thakur (in saffron) at a condolence meeting in Bhopal

■ **By Bhavna Vij-Aurora with Ambresh Mishra and Farzand Ahmed**

Pragya Singh Thakur, in her saffron robes and angelic face, hardly seems the poster girl for Hindu militancy. Yet, as Anti Terror Squads (ATS) in four states made a series of arrests in connection with the bomb blasts in Malegaon and Modasa which targeted Muslims, it appeared that a new form of revenge-based terrorism had arrived, and she may be its avenging angel. The investigations have already spanned Maharashtra, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh—and all leading to right-wing organisations,

some of them not even on the radar of intelligence agencies. Those arrested are all young and volatile, believing in and preaching "an-eye-for-an-eye" philosophy. Others, like the former army officer Major Ramesh Shivji Upadhyay, are educated and well-trained.

Pragya Singh, a regular at Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) meetings, was invited to various gatherings to give fiery speeches. "It was not uncommon for her to exhort the audience to kill Muslims. For her it was not violence but justice for Hindus, having been targets of Islamic terrorism since long," said a VHP activist, who has attended some of the meetings. Another key figure arrested by

Maharashtra ATS was Sameer Kulkarni from Madhya Pradesh, a young Hindu activist. In addition to these unlikely faces of terror, there has emerged an array of Hindutva organisations, two of which figure in connection with the blasts probe: Rashtriya Jagran Manch (RJM) to which Sadhvi Pragya was affiliated and Abhinav Bharat, of which Kulkarni was state *pramukh*.

The RJM is different from Hindu Jagran Manch, an ad hoc body of functionaries of various organisations affiliated with Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) that come together on controversial issues concerning places of worship. The RJM was floated less than a year ago by a